

Draft - expert review pending

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Topic 5.2 - Online etiquette (netiquette)

A real classroom situation

A head teacher in Nawabshah receives a message at 11 p.m. from a parent, written in capitals: "WHY HAS MY DAUGHTER'S MARK NOT BEEN UPDATED???" He replies with two lines, also short, also in capitals. By morning the exchange has been forwarded to the school's trustees as "evidence" of rudeness on both sides. Two people who would have been perfectly courteous face to face managed, in text, to insult each other - without either writing a single insult. The cause is not bad character; it is bad netiquette: written communication strips away tone, face and pause, and what you fail to add deliberately, the reader supplies angrily.

Netiquette: six situations, six rules

Situation	The netiquette rule	Why it matters
writing an email	greet, state the matter, sign your name	an unnamed message reads as a demand
a class chat	keep it about the lesson, use school hours	what you type at midnight arrives instantly, forever
replying when angry	wait, then write; or draft and delete	heat writes things calm would not
a discussion forum	respond to the idea, not the person	disagreement survives, insults end the discussion
forwarding messages	check first, then forward	your name carries what you pass on
using capitals	avoid whole messages in capitals	capitals read as shouting

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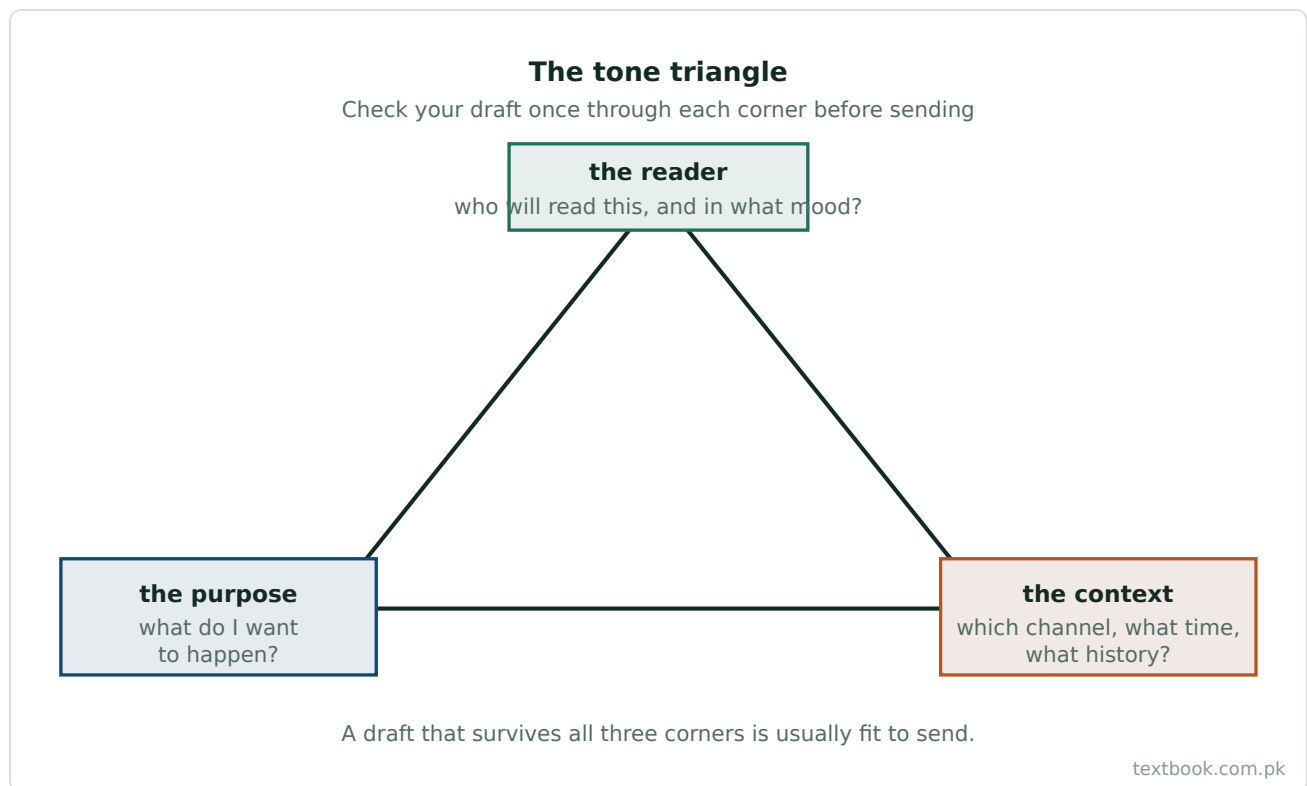
Explanation

Netiquette rules

Netiquette - network etiquette - is the set of conventions for behaving well in written digital communication: email, chat, forums, comment threads. Its entire reason for existing is that writing is a poor carrier of tone. Speech carries your face, your pause, your softening half-smile; text carries only the words, and the reader fills in the rest from their own mood. The 11 p.m. parent read indifference; the head teacher read aggression; both were reading themselves.

The rules fall into three groups. **Before you send:** identify yourself (a greeting and your name in email; a clear profile name in chat); state the matter plainly; check the recipient line - the wrong group is the classic disaster; and do not send heat. If a message makes your jaw tighten, write the reply, then leave it for an hour, then decide. **While you write:** mind the caps (a whole message in capitals reads as shouting); mind the punctuation ("???" reads as a slap); keep the message about the matter, not the person; and match the channel - a two-line "ok" to a colleague's careful paragraph reads as dismissal. **After you send:**

accept that it is permanent and forwardable. The screenshot does not carry your apology.



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A working tool for the moment of sending is the tone triangle in the figure: read your draft once through each corner. Through the **reader**: who receives this, and in what mood, and what will they fill in where my tone is missing? Through the **purpose**: what do I want to happen after they read it - and does this draft make that more or less likely? Through the **context**: is this the right channel, the right hour, the right point in the exchange? A draft that survives all three corners is usually fit to send.

A caution against the misconception that netiquette is "just politeness". Politeness smooths; netiquette also protects. The rule about not forwarding a pupil's or colleague's message outside its intended circle is Unit 4's data-protection duty in miniature. The rule about checking before forwarding a claim is Unit 6's misinformation defence. The rule about school hours is a boundary that protects the teacher as much as the parent. Etiquette, done seriously, is applied ethics.

Activity: The message clinic

Work in pairs. About 15 minutes.

1. Your teacher gives each pair three messages: the 11 p.m. capitals message from the opening story, a curt two-line reply to a parent's careful paragraph, and a class-chat message mocking a pupil's wrong answer.
2. For each message, diagnose the failures using the netiquette rules: what exactly went wrong, rule by rule?
3. Rewrite each message so it would achieve the same legitimate purpose (the parent wanted the mark updated; the teacher was busy; the pupil was wrong) without the damage.
4. Swap rewrites with another pair and check them against the tone triangle: reader, purpose, context.

Check your understanding

1. Define netiquette in one sentence and state why writing needs it more than speech does. (*Remember*)
2. Explain why a message in capitals reads as shouting, even though capitals carry no sound. (*Understand*)
3. A colleague sends you an angry message about a shared duty. Using the before-you-send rules, describe your next three actions. (*Apply*)
4. Name the three corners of the tone triangle and one question each corner asks. (*Remember*)

Summary

Netiquette is the etiquette of written digital communication, needed because text carries no tone and readers supply what is missing from their own mood. Its rules group into before you send (identify, state, check the recipient, do not send heat), while you write (caps, punctuation, matter-not-person, match the channel) and after you send (permanent and forwardable, screenshot included). The tone triangle - reader, purpose, context - is the check at the moment of sending.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can name the netiquette rules for email, chat and forums.
- ☐ I can diagnose what went wrong in a careless message, rule by rule.
- ☐ I can rewrite a careless message to achieve its purpose without the damage.

Try this at your practicum school

Look at one real message thread from the school's official communication (with permission), or recall one you have seen. Write three sentences: the tone failures it contained, the rule each failure broke, and how the exchange could have ended differently.

Summative task

Prepare a "netiquette card" for the staff room: one side for email to parents, one side for class groups, each side with five rules in imperative form and one worked example (before and after) of a message rewritten by the rules.

Marking guide (10 marks):

- Ten rules, each imperative, workable and distinct: 4 marks.
- The worked example's "before" has real failures and the "after" repairs them by the named rules (Analyse): 4 marks.
- Fits a card, plain language: 2 marks.

Further reading

- Common Sense Media. *Digital Citizenship Curriculum* (communication units). <https://www.commonsense.org/education/digital-citizenship>
- National Cybersecurity Alliance. *Stay Safe Online*. <https://staysafeonline.org/>
- Higher Education Commission, Pakistan. *ICT and Digital Literacy Guidelines*. <https://hec.gov.pk/english/services/universities/Pages/PolicyGuidelines.aspx>

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